Icons of the Faith

A visual matching and deduction game about Coptic iconography — Ages 10+ — 2-6 Players — 20-30 Minutes

Age Range	Players	Play Time	Difficulty
10+	**2-6**	**20-30 min**	**Moderate**

About This Game

Coptic icons are not decorations. They are theology written in colour and form. Every element — the gold background, the size of the eyes, the gesture of the hands, the objects a saint holds — carries meaning. Icons of the Faith teaches players to read these visual symbols by matching iconographic elements to their theological meanings.

As you play, you will begin to see icons the way the Church intended: as windows into heaven, not pictures on a wall.

> **Formation Goal:** Learning to read the visual language of the Coptic icon tradition — seeing theology, not just art.

Components

- **36 Icon Cards** — each showing an iconographic element (colour, gesture, symbol, or object) found in Coptic icons
- **36 Meaning Cards** — each explaining the theological meaning of an iconographic element
- **1 Reference Sheet** — quick-reference guide with all 36 icon-meaning pairs
- **1 Leader Guide** — background on Coptic iconography and discussion prompts

72 cards total. Print on cardstock for best results.

Setup

1. Print the card sheets on cardstock. Cut along the card borders.
2. Separate the cards into two decks: **Icon Cards** (white background) and **Meaning Cards** (light purple background).
3. Shuffle each deck separately.
4. **For a standard game:** Select 12 Icon Cards at random and find their 12 matching Meaning Cards (24 cards total). Return the rest to the box.
5. **For a full game:** Use all 36 pairs (72 cards).
6. Lay all selected cards face-down in a grid, mixing Icon and Meaning Cards together.

How to Play — Memory Match

1. The oldest player goes first (the elders lead in the Church).
2. On your turn, flip over any two cards.
3. **Match:** If an Icon Card matches its Meaning Card, say the connection aloud (e.g. "Gold background represents the divine light of God"). Keep the pair and take another turn.
4. **No match:** Flip both cards back face-down. The next player takes their turn.
5. Play continues until all pairs are matched.
6. The player with the most pairs wins.

Variant: Icon Detective

A deduction game for older players who want a greater challenge.

1. Deal 5 Meaning Cards face-up in the centre of the table. These are the "mysteries."
2. Shuffle all 36 Icon Cards. Deal 6 to each player (adjust for player count). Place the rest face-down as a draw pile.
3. On your turn, play an Icon Card from your hand onto one of the face-up Meaning Cards and explain the connection.
4. The group votes: does the match make sense?
   - **If accepted:** You score the pair. Replace the Meaning Card from the Meaning deck.
   - **If rejected:** Take your Icon Card back. Draw one card from the draw pile. Your turn ends.

5. If you cannot play, draw a card and pass.
6. Play until the draw pile is empty and no more matches can be made. Most pairs wins.

Matching Guide

Refer to the **Reference Sheet** for the complete list of all 36 icon-meaning pairs. During your first few games, keep the Reference Sheet face-up so players can check matches. As players learn, put it away.

Tips for Leaders

- Before playing, show the group a real Coptic icon (printed or on screen). Ask: "What do you notice? What do you think it means?"
- When a pair is matched, pause briefly: "Why do you think the iconographer chose to show this?"
- For younger players (ages 10-12), start with 8-10 pairs from the first 18 (colours, features, and gestures).
- For youth groups, use all 36 pairs and play Icon Detective for richer discussion.
- Connect to the Liturgy: "Next time you are in church, look at the icons. What can you read now that you could not before?"
- Use the Leader Guide for deeper background on the Coptic icon tradition.

> *"We do not worship icons — we venerate the saints depicted in them, and through them we lift our hearts to God." — Coptic Orthodox teaching on iconography*